take care of each other

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by n7punk

Summary

Months after the war has ended and peace has spread across Etheria, a quiet conversation about before – about the things that happened and their consequences – sparks an idea that might be their worst yet, but if they can actually safely open a portal again, rescuing those inside would be worth the risk. It has to be, because they're doing this one way or another. (Or, the one where they rescue Angella)

Notes

Yes, this is canon compliant uwu I started writing this back May last year because I had Opinions but then I realized I would have to like… actually write it? and that's bogus so I stopped lmao. But now I'm finally finishing it.
Also reference's Entrapta's line from 'Don't Go' (which is, as always, canon to this series)

Chapter 1: The Rescue

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

There's a lot to work through, after the war – trauma, apologies, and no small number of revelations. There are stories to exchange from both sides. There are hard moments to discuss. There's the *portal*.

They've had a few conversations about it, but it is only after they have discussed how they got into and *out* of it that they end up lying side-by-side on Adora's chaise lounge as Adora starts telling her about the weird version she saw of Bright Moon inside the portal. She ends up backtracking until she gets to the beginning of the portal, telling Catra everything that happened from her perspective – at least as best she can given how things kept jumping around.

Catra is mostly just listening, sprawled out on Adora's lap. Adora is petting her as she talks, gentle fingers running through her hair or blunt nails scratching at her scalp. It is a touchy subject, but they've addressed it before, which is why Catra can earnestly listen this time. It is also why she is able to pick things up that she missed in previous retellings.

Things like how everybody in the portal world was alive – people like Micah, who they thought was dead at the time. It's later in the story, when Adora is telling Catra about reaching the Crystal Castle with Glimmer and Bow at her side, that Catra has a *realization* and goes deathly still in Adora's lap. Adora immediately halts, a nervous energy rolling off of her as she shifts to carefully massage the base of Catra's ears.

"Do you want me to stop?" she asks, her voice gentle. Part of addressing issues in a healthy manner is only talking about them when both of them are ready and up to talking. However, Catra is far from upset in this moment. She is running through everything that Adora has told her about the portal before – not just went Catra activated it, but the first time when Mara stopped the world from unraveling as well.

"Can you repeat that part?" Catra asks, her voice quiet. Her face is semi-buried in Adora's thighs right now. For a moment, Adora hesitates. Catra feels Adora shift under her to crane her head backwards, taking a look at where Melog is curled up in their bed. They are lounging calmly, nothing about them indicating that Catra is upset. After a moment, Adora resumes her slow petting over her ears.

"We blinked from the Crypto Castle into the Woods, in front of the Beacon. Mara was there. It felt like a symbol of how I was failing, seeing that I couldn't fix it when she did. I tried to talk to her, but-" Adora starts to repeat, but she cuts off when Catra stirs and sits up. Adora's expression is curious, bordering on *terrified* as she catches the distant look in Catra's eyes.

"Mara was there, in the portal," Catra repeats. Adora pauses, and then nods, blinking a little at Catra.

A second later, it clicks for her too, and her eyes go wide.

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Adora volunteers that Catra ease Glimmer into it because Adora may be capable of giving great speeches and rallying cries, but she also isn't known for her tact. Growing up in the Fright Zone tends to do that to a person. She can be blunt. Catra doesn't think that she really knows how to couch this revelation with the fact that it might be *wrong* herself, but she can at least ease Glimmer into her hypothesis.

"Remember the whole…. Portal thing?" Catra asks at their next meeting together. They are in Catra's office, supposed to be going over propositions from the day, but Catra has been planning out how she will say this all day. She hasn't gotten very far, but if she agonizes over this much longer, she is going to end up blurting it out just as bluntly as Adora would. Adora is already stationed out in the hall in case Glimmer needs her, pacing far too loudly. Melog walks alongside her, banished from the room so as to not give away Catra's anxiety.

Catra is *pretty* sure that Glimmer knows that at least Adora is there, if not Melog as well, but she probably just thinks that Adora is eager for Catra to finish her day's work. It wouldn't be unusual – being Queen Glimmer's Royal Advisor can involve long hours, and Adora is usually as eager to spend time together as Catra is – but Adora also isn't usually pacing with a tracker pad, ready to call in Bow at any moment but not wanting to tell him before Glimmer finds out.

Glimmer levels Catra with an incredibly unimpressed look. They have had three conversations related to the portal, involving Glimmer letting Shadow Weaver use her power to torture Catra right beforehand, why Catra pulled the lever – shockingly, the first and the second were related – and what brought the portal to a *close*. Glimmer doesn't blame Catra for it, at least not anymore. She almost did the same damn thing with the Heart, after all – actually, just like Catra, Glimmer *did* do it, it was just stopped by Adora once again.

"Listen, there are no good icebreakers relating to this," Catra tells her, sitting back in her chair. Glimmer actually chuckles, though there is an edge of nervousness to it as she waves her hand in a *go ahead* gesture. Catra has thought all day about how to go about this – she even had trouble sleeping last night as she mulled it over – and all she can think to do is to tell Glimmer all the reasons that they could be wrong before she gets her hopes up.

"Razz told Adora that it all happened before when Mara moved Etheria," Catra says, even though she knows Adora already told Glimmer that. Glimmer nods slowly, still visibly skeptical.

"Remember how Micah was alive in the portal and everyone just thought it was because it was an alternative timeline?" Catra continues. This time Glimmer hesitates, tensing as if to brace herself before she nods again. Catra couldn't be poking at a touchier subject right now, but she is doing it for a good reason.

“As far as Adora and I can tell, everybody we saw inside the portal was alive. There were plenty of people we could have seen in the Fright Zone, like Scorpia’s moms, but we never did,” Catra adds. Micah was the only “exception” that they knew of, and that turned out not to be an exception. Glimmer narrows her eyes.

“Catra, just say whatever it is,” Glimmer says. She doesn’t sound annoyed, just a little edgy. Catra knows that she would want anyone else bringing up the portal to her to just cut to the chase, but the couching is necessary. They might find out in an hour that Catra’s theory is bullshit. She sighs, glancing towards the door and almost wishing that she insisted Adora do this instead, but it felt like owning up to it a little to be the one who told Glimmer.

“We don’t know how Mara solved it back then, but you guys *saw* her in the portal, which might mean that whatever she did, she is still alive and was just trapped inside,” Catra explains, doing her best to cut to the chase without raising false hope. Glimmer’s eyes go wide, her lips parting as she thinks about that. After a moment, her expression falls, tinging with sadness.

“What, she spent a thousand years in limbo after sealing it? Catra, that’s horrifying to even think about,” Glimmer says, sounding genuinely upset. Catra bites her lip. This isn’t the reaction she was expecting. Glimmer is right that is sounds horrifying to be locked in… wherever Mara was, apparently not aging and not dying, but there are implications to that.

“Maybe she isn’t the only one,” Catra finally says. Maybe she is, or maybe the entire theory is wrong, but if it *isn’t* then they have to try. And that means they have to tell Glimmer. Catra watches Glimmer’s eyes go wide. A moment later, they well up with tears.

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Having a theory is fine. Proving it is hard. They go to Entrapta. After all, she was the one who really built the first portal machine. The problem is that they don’t really know where they’re trying to go, but Entrapta is excited about the possibility regardless. Catra can’t help but suspect it is for a similar reason that she is: if they are right, it is a way to fix a mistake from their past. The years in between still happened and their effects will never go away, but if they can give Glimmer her mom back, it will help their guilt.

Entrapta confirms that it could be *possible* a pocket dimension was left behind when the portal was sealed. She doesn’t know if it would sustain life or be more like a void, but they have to try, for Mara’s sake as much as Angella’s. If Mara has really been in there this whole time, they need to get her out. From Adora’s recollection, Mara didn’t speak when they saw her. She looked shocked to be seeing anyone. Of course she would be after spending a thousand years alone. Who knows if she has even been aware of the passage of time in there, especially since she hasn’t appeared to age.

There are so many questions. As Entrapta sets to investigating them, trying to find a way to detect a pocket dimension and then build a new portal to reach it – with Etheria pulled out of

Despondos it should be safe again, but they also have to contend with emergency plans if it isn't – dreams begin plaguing Bright Moon Castle. Catra and Adora both start reliving the portal in their sleep, or worse, have dreams about how it could go wrong *this* time around.

"Maybe we shouldn't do it," Adora murmurs one night. They are both sat up in bed, on opposite ends of it with their feet tangled together as darkness surrounds them. Melog is lying stretched out alongside their legs, their head resting in Adora's lap as Adora pets their ears. Adora's eyes are downcast, fixed down on Melog in her lap. She looks exhausted. It has been awhile since either of them has had a nightmare bender, but late night conversations like this are a familiar ghost. Catra turns her head, looking out the balcony doors so she can see the stars hanging up in the sky.

"Glimmer is going to do it. She has to try. We knew that when we told her," Catra returns. It isn't a surprise what triggered Adora's nightmares tonight. They had a meeting with Entrapta this afternoon. She identified some kind of anomaly. It wasn't all that clear, but the summary was that she thinks she might know where they need to open the new portal to once she and Hordak are done building their latest version of the portal machine.

Hordak has been doing "community service" as a researcher in the Crypto Castle ever since the end of the war and them working together on the new machine was a no brainer, but there is always the fear that it will go just as poorly as last time. Adora almost volunteered herself to seal it if necessary in the meeting this afternoon. Catra saw it in her eyes. Her expression was distraught, but as she parted her lips, she looked to Catra and stopped.

"It's not going to be you, Adora," Glimmer dismissed upon glancing their way. Adora looked sheepish, shrinking down in her seat as Catra looked at her with burning eyes, communicating *I will kill you if you speak* without having to say anything herself. "If nothing else, do you know how stupid it would be for us to lock away She-ra?" Glimmer added, rolling her eyes. She didn't like the topic of the meeting. She didn't want to acknowledge how badly this could go. Catra can't blame her.

"But what if we just lose Micah too?" Adora whispers back. Catra swallows, turning back to look at Adora's downcast face. He ended up volunteering just moments after Adora quieted herself. Everyone's immediate instinct was to tell Micah *no*, but they had to designate *someone* to seal it before they could even think of activating it. Micah's argument was the only one that made sense. Everybody else was needed. Glimmer has to rule Bright Moon if they can't get Angella out. She-ra is needed, as are all the princesses. Even Catra and Bow have roles in ruling or the Princess Alliance. While Micah helps, he doesn't have an official role. That wasn't the real reason, though. The real reason was what he said after calmly sitting through Glimmer telling him that he absolutely wouldn't be the one.

"I'd be with Angella again," he said, stopping the room just as surly as he did when he first volunteered. That wasn't the entire conversation, but none of them could come up with an argument to that, much less somebody else to put forward in his place. Hopefully nobody would have to stay behind, but they had to prepare for it to be *somebody*. Glimmer took Micah aside after the meeting. Catra didn't see either of them for the rest of the evening.

"If it was you in there, I would volunteer in a heartbeat," Catra returns. Adora's eyes snap up to lock onto her own. Catra just shrugs. They both know that Adora would do the say damn

thing for her. She almost did it for Angella, after all. Adora's eyes are fiery when they meet Catra's. Catra can't help but be reminded of the look that she gave Adora during the meeting earlier.

"See how it feels?" Catra asks. Adora tilts her face down, her expression dark. Catra knows that part of the reason Adora would make a sacrifice like that would be to make sure that Catra is able to have a safe life even without her, but if she had a chance to be reunited with Adora, no matter where she was, she would take it. From the way Micah talks about Angella and the stories other have told, Catra gets the impression that Angella and Micah were stupidly in love.

"I think they're like us," she murmurs, her voice low. Adora nods, her eyes still downcast. They both know what Catra means – that's part of being *them*. Knowing that Micah is prepared to do this won't make them miss him less if he has to go through with it, though. Catra swallows. "It will work," she assures Adora. Optimism isn't usually her thing, but they have no reason to think that that it won't. Entrapta has been experimenting with teleportation technology for a little while now and Prime's portals didn't have issues. It should work, it's just a dark thought if it doesn't.

Adora bites her lip. Melog nuzzles their head into her stomach, prompting her to begin massaging their ears again. She has that expression that says she wants to believe Catra. The only problem is that Adora was made to worry. She was a little overstimulated after her nightmare, hence why they ended up at opposite ends of the bed, but she hasn't seemed to mind Melog slowly climbing into her lap, so Catra cautiously shifts forward and crawls up the bed.

Adora watches her approach with a gently softening expression. When Catra reaches her side, she lifts her arm. Catra happily tucks into her side, resting her head on Adora's shoulder and nuzzling at her neck. It usually calms them both. Melog mews in Adora's lap, somehow managing to lift up just their butt while keeping their front half on the bed. They flop their hindquarters over onto Catra so they can sprawl across both their laps at once.

"Even if we don't find them, it'll work," Catra assures Adora, throwing one arm over her to hug her tightly. Adora lets out a heavy sigh, but after a long moment, she raises her arm and hugs Catra back. A few seconds later, she finally nods.

"It'll work," she echoes back. Catra hopes that she is right, or the nightmares are going to get a lot worse. She has already found Glimmer wandering the halls late at night once.

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"Sometimes it feels like a mistake," Entrapta says, her tone conversational and even somewhat cheerful as she stares at the machine's structure. The frame of the portal is still being built, but seeing it in person brings up memories. Entrapta has made some changes to the design – probably for the same reason that she called Catra to come see it today – but

there is only so much that tweaking and painting it purple can do. Entrapta has added what appear to be cat stickers all along the right side, and while they help with making it less intimidating, the lever is still sitting not too far away.

It doesn't do anything yet. Entrapta painted it pastel blue. Catra can't but feel that she picked that color for her benefit. The portal base is apparently pink, but Catra can't see that. She is grateful for any change to the lever. She saw it in her nightmares for months. She still does sometimes. Having it be smaller and pastel helps a little, but she knows what Entrapta means. She has had this conversation with Adora too, but it is different to talk with someone else who shares the blame and the guilt.

"It's fixing a mistake," she returns. She hopes that she is right. When they went to Entrapta with their theory, there had been a few long, hesitant moments before she seemed to latch onto the scientific side of the question and began gibbering about how it related to her theories. Catra made sure Adora sat before they broached the subject so they could stay and let Entrapta talk for as long as she wanted to. The request for help was sure to trigger something in her. Catra still remembers Entrapta referring to the portal as *her* machine that almost destroyed reality on the trip back to Etheria from Prime's ship.

Catra sat and listened to Entrapta talk for an hour. Adora didn't do as good of a job at nodding along and looking engaged throughout it, but Entrapta didn't seem to mind. Catra was listening, even if she didn't always understand, and Entrapta seemed to understand that. She offered Catra small smiles sometimes throughout the rant. Catra is pretty sure that she was either processing her emotions or shoving them down during that time. Whatever she was doing, she needed to do it before she could start working on building the machine again.

"Sometimes I try to fix things and I just make them worse," Entrapta responds. She finally looks up from the machine to look at Catra, fixing her gaze on her tail. She doesn't understand Catra as well as Adora does – she doesn't think that anybody ever could – but she made a chart on what Catra's tail movements mean back in the Horde. Catra walked in on Entrapta explaining it to Scorpia while she listened intently not long before Shadow Weaver escaped. One glance at it told Catra that only a few of her movements had made it on there, but Catra is almost certain that Entrapta has improved the list since the end of the war, especially because she has a much better sample size for Catra's joyful signals now.

"But you always keep trying to do better. You're the one who taught me to do that," Catra returns. Entrapta blinks down at her tail once before looking up and offering her a small smile. Her eyes are fixed on Catra's ears rather her eyes, but Adora does that sometimes too. Catra offers her a smile back. Entrapta has come a long way since Catra first met her, but building a monument to one of her worst moments – and one that precipitated months of darkness for her – has clearly brought up the same insecurities for her that it has brought up for Catra.

This undertaking has affected them *all*. Adora has nightmares about Catra, Catra has nightmares about Entrapta, Entrapta has nightmares about Beast Island, Glimmer only got her father from Beast Island as an adult but now has nightmares about losing him just like she did her mother. All of them are unsure of how it will turn out, but still, this venture is a *hopeful*

one and they have to see it through. Catra gives Entrapta a break from struggling with eye contact, turning back to face the machine.

“Don’t look at it as a portal. Look at it as a gateway to bring them back. And don’t just think about Angella. Think about everything we could learn about the First Ones if we’re able to rescue Mara too,” Catra tells her. She needs this as a chance at redemption just as much as Entrapta does. Entrapta looks back to the machine, and after a moment, Catra sees a spark return to her eye. It takes a few seconds, but then her almost feral energy is back as a smile spreads across her face.

“We could learn so much about how they interfaced with all of their technology and what things were meant to do! Do you think she knows how to build anything herself? Imagine if we had *brand new First Ones’ technology*,” Entrapta rushes out, excitedly. Catra can’t help but smile. This is the Entrapta that she is used to. Though she can be a lot, this is her friend. She would rather see her excited like this than quiet and doubting.

“She’ll probably be a jock just like Adora. But who knows,” Catra tells Entrapta. They really don’t know what state Mara will be in if they *do* manage to rescue her, so she might not be able to do any of those things even if she could once, but they can hope that she hasn’t lost too much of herself in the portal. Entrapta cocks her head a little, and then she shakes it, still smiling.

“Tech might not be Adora’s strong suit, but she knows a lot! She taught me to read First Ones’ writing, you know,” Entrapta corrects her, starting forward and pulling a wrench seemingly *out of her hair* to adjust something on the machine. Catra finds herself smiling. Sometimes even Adora’s friends don’t give her that credit, but Entrapta really does have the ability to find the good in anybody. After all, she found it in Hordak.

Catra has always had a soft spot for anybody who gives Adora the credit she’s due. Entrapta is a good person, regardless of her mistakes. She wouldn’t be setting aside her own fears to help Glimmer like this if she wasn’t.

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The clones turn out to be helpful. A number of them stayed on Etheria after the war. Some of them were trouble, but suddenly losing the hivemind left those of them who *didn’t* want to try to resurrect Prime feeling lost. They were often disconnected from their own memories and pasts. Still, some of them remembered critical information from when they were connected. Entrapta managed to recruit a few of them to join her newly setup research center in Dryl. They have been helping with establishing space flight, interplanetary communication, teleportation, and now, building a new portal machine.

It takes much longer to figure out where the portal’s pocket dimension is and how they *think* they should access it than it does to build and calibrate the machine. When everything is ready, they gather in the basement of the new research center built onto the Crypto Castle.

Catra has seen the machine in various stages of construction, but it is more daunting to be gathered around it knowing that someone – definitely not *her* – is about to pull that lever. Nothing should happen – well, nothing bad – but Catra is still nervous, not the least because the two people standing immediately before the portal are Micah and She-ra.

They don't actually know where the portal will go to. It might not be anywhere a human can survive. The plan is for Adora to stick her head through and see what is on the other side. If She-ra can survive in space, wherever this lets out should be okay. Entrapta has made a safety harness for Adora, attached to a powerful wench on the other end of the room. Most of the princesses are gathered around it. It is bolted into the floor, but who knows, they might be needed and there is only so much room near the machine.

Everyone in the room has an anchor line bolted somewhere. This portal should be stable so nothing should get sucked into it like before, but they still don't *know* that nothing will go wrong. This might be the safest experiment Entrapta has ever done. She has planned for a lot of eventualities. Still, Catra's tail is lashing and Melog, tethered in a harness beside her, is pacing back and forth on their short safety line with agitation. They finally sit down, though their mane spikes uncertainly, as Glimmer calls the countdown, takes a deep breath, and then pushes the lever herself.

For a second, energy arcs off the crystal that Entrapta has placed in the portal's center to act as a power source. For a few terrified moments, the fear that this will be just like the last time grips Catra. All the changes and it could come to nothing. The beams of lightning arc, but they aren't lashing out at the room as if trying to escape containment. Instead they warp, wrapping around the crystal. A moment later, the light expands, and then the portal is filled with light, no more wild arcs threatening the room.

Adora and Micah, who had temporarily shielded their eyes with their arms along with the rest of the room, both look up to face the portal as Entrapta rushes to type on her computer. She was wearing her welding mask for the activation, but now she pushes it up to get a clearer look at the screen.

"Portal appears to be holding strong. Energy levels are within acceptable standards, but they are building. If they don't drop on their own, we may only have seventy-eight to eighty-five seconds before we have to shut it down or it could turn into a bomb," Entrapta rushes out, her voice only slightly frenzied. From where Catra is standing, she can see charts spiking, all of them climbing upwards at a steady pace. Melog growls at her side, their mane spiking as they begin pacing again. Okay, so this is a brand new kind of bad. Catra will take a bomb they can *hopefully* shut off over reality ripping apart, but her heart is racing as Adora looks back over her shoulder to Catra, her expression anxious and unsure.

"Well be *fast*," Catra tells her, unable to hide the anxiety in her voice. She is so scared of what is on the other side of that energy mass. She doesn't want these to be her last-

"We don't have much time. I estimate seventy-four to eighty seconds now. Go!" Entrapta calls. Adora's expression sets with determination and she does a small run up to the portal, crossing over the safety line marked on the floor in tape and sticking her head straight in the portal, along with her upper shoulders. Catra finds herself reaching for something to squeeze. She ends up with her hand on Melog's head, her fingers flexing uselessly against their crown.

It isn't enough. With her other hand, she grabs onto the braided metal cable bolted onto the floor beside her that acts as her personal safety line. The cable seems unnecessary now – nothing is getting sucked into the portal like before – but she clings to it for dear life as she stares at Adora's back and waits.

Adora shifts a little where she stands, stretching forward until she has her entire torso in the portal, but she doesn't pull back to give them an update. With every inch of her that disappears inside, Catra swears her heartrate climbs. She wishes she know what was *happening*. Her cable doesn't even go far enough for her to reach the portal, just barely able to reach the safety line where Micah and Adora were standing at first. Just when Catra is about to call impatiently to Entrapta, Adora pulls herself back out of the portal quickly.

"Sixty-eight to seventy-three seconds!" Entrapta updates before Catra can speak. Adora looks fine from what Catra can see, but she is a blur of motion of she jogs backwards away from the portal.

"Got it! I can see Angella," Adora shouts before sprinting forward and *leaping* through the portal. Catra's heart stops. She can hear several others gasping in response, but Catra can't look away from the safety chain still unraveling and disappearing inside the portal.

"When do we stop it?" Scorpia calls from where she is standing beside one of the handles for the winch that Adora's safety line is spooled on. Catra can't take it anymore. She rushes forward, forced to come to a halt at the edge of the safety line, standing right beside Micah. Melog yowls for her, warning her it isn't safe in her mind, but their lead doesn't let them go quite as far as hers thanks to their different style of harness. They are forced to pull up a few inches short, barely able to nose at her hip as she stands right at the edge of her tether, her body straining forward again it. She can't *stand* this.

"When we're down to thirty-four seconds so we can reel her in before it overloads. Glimmer, if I call to shut it off, do it even if she's inside," Entrapta instructs, looking up from her screen for the first time to make eye contact with Glimmer. Catra's heart stops.

"What?!" multiple voices in the room cry, including Glimmer and Catra. Entrapta is already looking back down to her screen.

"We can always let it cool down and open another one to get her. We can't reverse an explosion. Fifty-nine to sixty-one seconds," Entrapta responds. Catra's stomach feels like a hole at the idea of leaving Adora *behind*. How long would it take to cool down? Minutes? Hours? They can't leave Adora for that long. They'll have no chance of getting her back if they blow themselves up, but Catra doesn't know if she can take it. She stares at the chain still disappearing inside the portal, though it seems to have slowed.

"How long?" Micah asks besides her. It feels like an eternity has passed, but Catra knows it must have just been a few seconds. She feels his hand land on her shoulder, anchoring her and likely himself as well. She can feel her tail hitting his leg as it lashes, but she can't stop it.

"Fifty-seven to fifty-nine seconds," Entrapta replies. Catra is aware the time range is shifting somewhat as Entrapta runs her calculations, but it still feels like way more than two seconds

have passed. She is seconds away from cutting her chain and jumping in after Adora herself. Instead, she is forced to stand still as Micah clutches her shoulder almost as if to stop her from doing just that. If Melog could reach her to do so, she is sure they would be trying to pin her right now, but they are just as worried about Adora as she is.

They have until they're down to the last ten seconds. Then she is going in herself.

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The seconds tick by. Different people call for time updates, but every time only a fraction of how long it feels like it has been has actually passed. They reach forty seconds and the line is still pulling forward, but slower than before, and jerkily.

"Reel the line in! We have thirty-five seconds left!" Entrapta calls. Catra whips her head around, watching as Scorpia, Bow, Mermista, and Sea Hawk all reach for the two large handles on either side of the wench. It takes a second of scrambling for them to grab on as it unwinds, but they pull it to a halt. The line goes taught, wavering in the air only a few inches from Catra where it stretches into the portal and sways. A second later, the crew begins to turn the wench back. For the first few seconds, it is agonizingly slow, especially compared to how fast the cable unwound, but then they start to get momentum going and reel it in.

Before Catra's heart can lift, the cable jerks abruptly, slackening. Her blood goes cold.

"What's going on?" Glimmer demands. Catra is too breathless to speak as the line goes taut again, but this time it is reeling in much faster – almost like there is nothing attached to the other end anymore.

"Keep going! Thirty seconds!" Entrapta calls from her position. Catra doesn't think – she reaches for her safety belt and slices her claws through it so she can run forward to the portal. Micah tries to grab her, but she is too fast for him to react and she rushes over the safety line even as Melog yowls.

"Catra!" Multiple people call, but the only way they can stop her is in they unfasten their own safety lines. She runs toward the portal, the last thing that she thought she would be doing today, and grips the edge of the frame with one hand as she plunges her head inside. She isn't really thinking, but if she were, she would argue that it probably isn't too dangerous if Adora jumped in – probably.

She wasn't expecting all the light on the other side. It is like a void, but instead of the blackness of space, all is light. It looks like the world-ending light that destroyed the world in the portal and left her corrupted and broken. The only thing she can distinguish is the safety line stretching out before her with a dark shape on its end. Catra feels like she can't breathe – and maybe she really *can't* – as she takes in Angella holding onto the tow line, which has been cut just like Catra feared. It is still pulling in Angella though, who is moving through the void of light almost like she is being pulled through water.

Adora is nowhere in sight, but Catra can also barely make out anything except Angella's grey form and the silhouette of her wings against the void. Catra might pass out. She can't breathe and she's panicking. Where is *Adora?* How did she disappear? Catra tries to call, to ask a question or say the time, but when she opens her mouth, the air is sucked out of her lungs. There is nothing here but light and she can't even scream for Adora.

Hands land on her and she is pulled forcibly from the portal. She goes tumbling backwards, falling to the floor of the research center and scrabbling. Micah is ridiculously strong, though, and he is doing his level-best to keep her held down. Catra lets out a hissing yowl as she scrambles to get her hands and feet underneath her even as she gasps for air. His line was long enough to reach the portal in case he needed to seal it and she curses it now. Melog is calling out to her, but all she can think is *where is Adora?*

"Catra, what's going on over there?" Glimmer calls, her voice cutting through the other panicked sounds filling the room. Not that Glimmer isn't panicked too, but somehow that is the only voice that Catra hears.

"Angella's on the line," Catra gasps out. Beneath her, Micah's grip falters. Catra uses the momentary distraction, shoving herself up. As he scrambles to catch her, she takes a deep breath and makes maybe her stupidest decision: she jumps in. It is the only way she can think of to keep them from stopping her finding Adora.

It is funny how the world shifts the second that she is submerged in the light. Her momentum cuts the second she hits the light and she only drifts slowly forward from the gateway behind her. The line is stretching beside her and she can grab it to haul herself back in, but now she is fully in the pocket dimension, everything feels different. She can breathe – well, actually, she *can't*, but it doesn't bother her. She doesn't feel breathless. She doesn't need the air.

Her heart isn't racing anymore either. Her mind is still going quickly – at least, she thinks – but she is hardly perceiving her own body. Everything has just seemed to stop. Carter blinks out into the void of the corrupting light searing against her eyes and finally gets a good look at Angella. She is closer now, almost to the Portal. Her face is close to panicked, but only *close*, because Catra doesn't think anything can be fully *something* in this strange world. As they make eye contact, Angella turns her head and looks up.

Catra's gaze follows her. Above them is the same light all around them, but it is cut by a series of rainbow disks. Catra recognizes them as the light platforms that Adora learned how to make after breaking the sword. The series of launchpads leads up high above them, but a large dark figure leaps between them, making its way back down. Actually, it isn't just one. The figure is still distant and everything is hard to see in the midst of the consuming light, but one large figure carries something over its shoulder.

Catra reaches out, fighting through the light to grab onto the line with one hand. She wraps her hand around it and lets herself be pulled to safety. She tumbles back to reality and immediately seizes as her heart and breathing restarts.

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For what feel like the longest seconds of her life, Catra's body seizes and panics, but she stabilizes in Micah's arms again. Melog is nuzzling into the side of her head now. They slipped their line to reach her. People are still yelling around her. She can't understand anything but the blood rushing in her ears. When she is recovered enough to regain control of her body, she lifts her arms up. She is on her back in Micah's arms, splayed before the portal. A moment later, Angella pulls through, convulsing just like Catra did as she releases the rope and falls into the pile.

The call of "*Mom!*" is so shrill that it once again cuts through the rest of the sound. Catra wraps around Angella tightly, pinning her arms by her sides as she twitches and convulses to avoid her hitting herself. It seems to last much longer for her than it did for Catra. It could be her sense of time was warped, or it could be that she was in there longer and the return to reality is more of a shock. Either way, Catra becomes aware of a countdown in the background as Micah starts crying beneath her, also trying to hold Angella's body still along with Catra.

"It's alright, my love, I'm right here. Glimmer's here. We're all right here," Micah rushes to assure her, his hands on her head as he tries to support it and stop it from hitting anything. The twitches are calming now, but Angella is still panting a mile a minute. Did Catra do that to? She really isn't sure. There is nothing she can do if something *is* wrong through. She can't help Angella besides holding her still, and she is starting to go limp now anyway. Instead, Catra stares at the portal and tries to sort through the din of noise to make out Entrapta's voice.

"Nine!" she calls, or at least Catra *thinks* she does. She could have heard it wrong, but it's enough to spur her into action. She twists out from beneath Angella, leaving Micah to bring her back to reality as she scrambles forward and grabs the portal frame so she can stick just her head in again. It is an odd feeling of cognitive dissonance. Nothing slows like before, but all the noise cuts out, and she can feel Melog's mouth on her wrist, grabbing her and pulling her back from jumping in again, but she isn't trying to get entirely inside. She cranes her neck up to search for Adora.

She-ra is carrying Mara down to the gateway, leaping between platforms, but Catra doesn't know if she is close enough. She digs her hand into the gateway, nearly punching her claws into it before she forces herself to let go and flings her free arm into the portal. She reaches up, silently beckoning Adora to her. She can't scream for her or even whisper, but she can reach and *hope*. Adora is upside down compared to her – this world doesn't seem to have its own rightside or bottom – and leaping off the bottom of the platforms she has made.

Catra is sure there used to be more, but the ones higher up seem to have faded as Adora leaps and grows closer, her head tilting back as if she is looking down at Catra, but she is too far for her face to be seen in the light glaring around it. Catra strains her hand up, silently beckoning Adora to her. Adora's form pauses and Catra's heartrate climbs. She doesn't have the time left to pause. Catra can see her arms moving, maybe beckoning to Catra, but she needs to spend every second that she can rushing towards the portal. Adora's form makes an

abrupt movement, but she remains standing on the platform. A moment later, a beam of golden light cuts through the rest of the bright void.

It isn't until its end has nearly reached Catra that she realizes what it is, but she desperately reaches out for it. The end of She-ra's whip wraps around her wrist and Catra grabs hold of it where it stretches past her wrist back to Adora. She yanks as hard as she can, twisting her hand in Melog's mouth to signal them. They immediately haul her backward, pulling her out of the portal. She nearly stumbles over Angella and Micah still on the floor as she careens backwards, but once both her arms are in reality, she tears her wrist from Melog's grip, unconcerned with their teeth or any damage she may sustain. She doesn't feel anything but adrenaline as she reaches out and grabs onto the whip to pull it with both hands.

"*Help!*" she calls desperately as she tries to run backwards and pull Adora through single-handedly. The water-like quality of the other dimension, while making traversal slow, also seems to help reduce the friction. Catra knows that She-ra is heavy, but she is able to run back several feet before a strong set of arms – well, pincers – wraps around her and starts running backwards with her like she and Adora both weigh little. Catra clings onto the whip for dear life, aware her arm will break if she lets go and all the force suddenly starts pulling on just her wrist.

"*Three!*" she hears right before light bursts through the portal as She-ra tumbles through, surrounded by a wash of golden light.

"*Adora*!" Catra calls for her as Adora tucks forward in a role, wrapping around Mara's limp form. There is a loud crackling sound as Glimmer slams the lever back into the shut off position and the portal warps, breaking apart into arcing beams of energy. Scorpia glances over her shoulder and suddenly slams on the brakes to avoid dragging Adora across the room, but Adora has already dismissed the whip. Suddenly all the forces pulling on Catra's body disappear, leaving her reeling. She is left gasping as she takes in the chaos of the room around her.

She can't see what is behind her – which is where most of the people waiting in the room were – but she can hear clinking and cursing, no doubt as they hurriedly undo their safety gear. A few small arcs of energy crackle around the crystal that powered the portal, but the gateway is gone, and the crackling is decreasing as the machine cools down. On the floor before the portal, Angella is lying limp and still on top of Micah. Melog noses at her fearfully. From her position by the lever, Glimmer is gaping at her parents, seemingly speechless. Entrapta is still typing away at her monitor, but she doesn't seem as frenzied and she isn't counting down anymore.

Adora is now standing in the middle of the room, apparently never suffering from the same convulsions that took the rest of them upon reentering reality. She-ra privilege, probably. She is holding Mara out at arm's length from under her armpits much like one would hold a cat that they are afraid of striking them. Mara is twitching just like the rest of them did upon returning to reality, though not hitting anything thanks to Adora holding her.

Catra struggles in Scorpia's arms and Scorpia sets her down immediately. Catra to dashes forward, skirting around Mara's twitching form with just enough room to avoid being hit before she runs around behind Adora and hugs her tightly. She can only really hug She-ra's

waist, but she buries her face between her shoulder blades and breathes deeply, taking in her scent and warmth to assure herself that Adora is okay. A moment later she feels Melog wrapping around them both from behind, nuzzling her hip and rubbing her with their shoulders as they try to assure her that everyone made it out alright.

"Um, guys, I need help? I don't know what she's doing," Adora calls to the room at large, concern obvious in her voice as she doesn't look away from Mara, who is down to just quaking now. The tremors were the longest part – that Catra remembers – for herself and Angella though, and they certainly aren't assuring to Adora. Hearing Adora's voice, however, is all the assurance that Catra needs. She begins purring instantly as she presses tight against her. Catra recovered. The others will too. She has Adora back, so everything will be okay.

Chapter End Notes

By the way, the fits in here weren't the same thing as a seizure, but if someone *is* convulsing, don't try to hold them down because you're more likely to cause injury than prevent it. Remove things from around them that they could hit (pull chairs away, etc) instead. I can't have the portal-recovery fits in here without mentioning that.

Chapter 2: The Recovery

Chapter Notes

> References to my other fics this chapter (not necessary to understand this fic though): a token of our love and foundations (this is set during the course of foundations). Also minor reference to Glimbow's engagement from 'dancing around the red line'.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mara is – maybe somewhat predictably – comatose. All four of them end up being rushed for medical attention before Angella has really seemed to register Micah in front of her. Catra is fine – well, recovered – and Adora doesn't seem to have ever suffered ill effects. Instead, she is worrying herself into knots over Mara's lack of consciousness and Angella's… well, when they do finally decide that Angella is stable and her body has readjusted to being *alive* again, it has been nearly an hour.

"Glimmer," Catra hears breathed from the other side of the curtain. Entrapta's research center has medical quarters stocked just as well as the medbay was back in the Horde – which isn't surprising, given the way that explosions tend to follow Entrapta – and laid out in a very similar manner, with curtains hanging between the beds. Catra is sitting with Adora at Mara's bedside as they wait for her to stir. It feels wrong to be listening in on the bed behind them, but they can't do much to block it out without leaving Mara, and Adora certainly isn't going to do that.

"I'm right here, Mom. You're going to be okay," Glimmer whispers back. There is a slight shifting in the sheets. Catra fixes her gaze on the rise and fall of Mara's chest. It seems the longer you spend in that stasis dimension, the more of a rude awakening it is when you return. They just have to hope that Mara is still capable of readjusting. They decided to give it sometime before Adora tries healing her. All signs point to all of them being fine overall upon re-emerging but going through shock, so pouring magic into Mara might only make it worse.

"Look at you," Angella whispers. There is an adoration in her voice that makes Catra's ears pin back. It is the voice of a mother reuniting with her child. Even with the war done for more than a year, Catra isn't used to those tones. They didn't exist in the Horde. If you loved someone – if you *were loved* – it was a friend, or romantically. Family didn't exist there, just a bond forged with your fellow soldiers. Brotherhood, but never motherhood.

"Yeah. It's been a while," Glimmer returns, her voice tear-filled. Catra wonders if she should pull the curtain back. Is the illusion of privacy comforting or deceiving? Glimmer knows they are right here, but Angella doesn't. She has been in and out of it ever since being pulled through. After all, she was in there for *years*. Catra is grateful that it just took her an hour to recover. It gives them hope that Mara might wake before she passes away of old age.

“But you look good. Did- did it work? Is everyone safe?” Angella asks. Her tone of voice breaks Catra’s heart. It is a tone of voice that she has heard from Adora too many times – *tell me the sacrifice was worth it. I need assurance that this misery was for something*. Catra never wants to hear that tone of voice from anyone ever again. Glimmer gives a small, gasping sob as she draws in air on the other side of the curtain.

“Yeah, they are. More than you know. I have so much to tell you, but the medic said to ease you into it. You were frozen for over two years,” Glimmer tells her. That was a decision that was made pretty much as soon as it was clear that Angella and Mara were both out of it. It’s why Micah isn’t here right now. He isn’t far, just in the hallway outside with Bow, but they thought it might send Angella into emotional shock if she woke up to his presence – or it might make her think this is all a delusion. It was better to get her stable. Micah understood, but it is definitely killing him. Every now and then Melog sends Catra visions of him pacing. They, like Bow, are waiting with him to provide him comfort. Catra can also tell Melog when it is time to let the others in.

“Two years… That’s not so much, is it?” Angella breathes. She sounds relieved. Catra can’t help but think about the nearly three years that she and Adora fought each other. Every day apart felt like an eternity. It still hurts to remember the anguish she was in then, but a life has blossomed in the year since. It has, in some ways, made all that pain meaningless to her. Those years can’t be gotten back, but they have so much time before them that they will eventually become an insignificant drop in the bucket. Two years, really, isn’t so many.

“No, Mom. It’s not that long. It- it might be closer to three years actually, but it doesn’t matter,” Glimmer promises her. The date of the initial portal opening is weird. Everybody knows it, but they usually do their best to forget it. It isn’t marked on any national calendar. It often rolls by and is only noticed a few weeks later with a strange, unpleasant shiver down the spine. Whenever the anniversary of Glimmer’s coronation is mentioned by someone, the portal looms in the background, a reminder of how it came to pass.

Maybe that will change now. Things are quiet aside from breathing and sniffling for a moment. Adora shuffles a little closer to Catra, their sides already brushing but now pressed together as Adora continues holding Mara’s hand. Catra finds her free hand and squeezes it to assure her. Maybe Adora is thinking the same thing as she is about what it is like to lose nearly three years.

“You haven’t been alone, have you?” Angella asks, her voice soft. Glimmer shakes her head so vehemently that Catra actually hears it.

“No, I haven’t. Everyone’s waiting outside. Adora is right here, actually,” Glimmer assures, the sound of her voice moving. Catra quickly looks up to find Glimmer has moved to the far end of the curtain and pulled it back just enough to send Adora a hopeful look. Adora immediately glances between Mara and Glimmer. Catra squeezes her hand, drawing her attention. When Adora meets her eyes, her gaze is already relieved.

“I’ll stay,” Catra whispers, trying to make her voice as low and inaudible as possible. She and Angella never actually met on the battlefield, but still, it would probably be a shock to see her here. The closest they ever got to each other was during the Battle of Bright Moon and they certainly weren’t close enough to hear each other’s voice, but Catra knows that Glimmer used

to – and still does – intimate her voice. It is so incredibly bad that she doesn't think anyone would be able to recognize her from it, but better safe than sorry.

Adora sends her a grateful smile and squeezes her hand back before she stands and follows Glimmer back around the curtain. Mara is hooked up to monitors that would immediately alert Adora if she so much as twitched, but it will make her feel better about walking away for a moment if Catra stays with her, so Catra will do it. Besides, she is probably low on the list of people that Angella needs to see. There is a slight gasp from the other side of the curtain as Adora rounds it.

"Hi, Angella," Adora says, her voice a bit tremulous but happy. Angella's loss has always weighed heavily on her mind – Adora always felt like it should have been *her*. Well, now it was no one. If Adora had been the one in there this entire time, Catra has no doubt that the war never would have resolved like this and they would still be in Despondos, unable to go back for anyone. It could have been a lot of people, but it *shouldn't* have been Adora. Catra hears rustling on the other side and Adora's soft footfalls as she walks closer to the bed.

"It's good to see you up. I was scared when I saw you in the portal. You looked so… vacant," Adora tells her, her voice muffled. She's hugging Angella, then. Her voice lifts at the end as she straightens up.

"It was hard to exist there. Nothing seemed to move, not time, not me, and eventually not even my thoughts. I am grateful to you for getting me out, but you had better have waited until you could do it safely," Angella says, her words going from slow and a bit quiet to scolding. She suddenly sounds like the many times that Glimmer has imitated her – minus the accent, which Glimmer has never been able to do perfectly despite being raised by her. Glimmer chuckles.

"Yes, Mom, we waited. We were, like, ninety-nine percent sure it wouldn't tear apart reality. And we took a lot of precautions," Glimmer assures her, a happiness in her tone that is almost soothing to here. It's just nice for Catra's friends to be happy with their families, even if Catra knows that she will never fully understand how they feel about them. Adora is her only family, and it is in a very different way. Adora chuckles from somewhere near the foot of the other bed.

"We really were safe, I promise. We're not in Despondos anymore, so we have our portal capabilities back," Adora assures Angella. She was probably making a face at Glimmer. Catra will take ninety-nine percent odds with most things – she took them with this, after all – but the way Glimmer phrased it wasn't all that assuring. There is a moment of silence from the other side in which Glimmer sniffles again. She isn't done crying yet. Catra doubts she will be for weeks. She is probably going to wake up in the middle of the night and start crying when she remembers that her mom is back for awhile now.

"Is everything alright?" Angella asks, softly. Catra feels her tail hit the curtain as it twitches. The answer to that question, overall, is *yes*, but there was a lot of *not alright* before they got there.

"Yeah, mom. Everything is fine. The world didn't fall apart," Glimmer promises, her voice soft. Catra hears Adora shuffle a little. A glance back over her shoulder reveals that Adora is

now standing right beside the curtain to Mara's side, her side just barely in view for Catra.

"Actually it did. But we fixed it, don't worry!" Adora adds. Glimmer immediately huffs. Catra sees Adora raise her arms, putting her hands up in surrender. Glimmer definitely glared at her. "We more than fixed it! Things are good now. Like, way better than when you left. You'll see," Adora promises Angella. It probably isn't all that assuring, but it is true. Angella left a world entrenched in war and has returned to one that is on the journey to healing from it. Things are likely better than she would have thought that they could be.

"The Horde?" Angella asks, clearly still holding some doubts. That really is the most pressing question. There is a long, conspicuous moment of silence. Catra looks up to find Adora has taken a half step back, putting her more solidly in Catra's line of sight. Adora exchanges a look with Glimmer, then looks behind the curtain to make eye contact with Catra, and then looks back at Glimmer and shrugs. Eventually, Glimmer sighs.

"We're supposed to ease you into everything so you don't go into shock again, but they're not a threat right now. Things really are better. Just trust me? We'll get to all of it once we're sure you're stable," Glimmer tells her. There is a suspiciously long silence before Angella sighs.

"Okay. I'll be patient. But I'll need the details soon, Glimmer. It's hard to believe they're just *not a threat*, anymore," Angella agrees. Glimmer laughs a little, mostly sounding relieved.

"Trust me, it took a lot to get there," she returns. That doesn't begin to cover it, but it seems to be enough to assure Angella, at least for the moment, because after a few seconds Adora conspicuously gives her a small wave and then ducks back onto Catra's side of the curtain to give Glimmer and Angella privacy.

"You look so mature," Angella says a moment later, her voice low. Glimmer is sniffling again. They're back to having a mother-daughter moment. Catra does her best to not listen as Adora sits back down. She can't just stop her hearing, but she tries to tune out as Angella and Glimmer whisper and cry back-and-forth. It's meant to be private.

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Catra isn't there when they tell Angella the brief version of the end of the war. Catra is grateful that she isn't there when Angella finds out about Micah either, or when they reunite. The only people there for that are the people who should be: family. Bow is there alongside Glimmer as she tells her mom, but he is going to be Angella's son-in-law one day, so it counts.

Angella returns to Bright Moon before Mara wakes up. There are nearly planet-wide celebrations for the return of the queen, even if she is the queen no more. Glimmer has been officially coronated and ruled in her absence for years now. The debate on what is to be done is brief and ends almost the moment that Angella finds out it is even taking place.

“Glimmer has proved herself as a queen and leader. One day the crown had to be passed on. Besides, I am no longer connected to the Moonstone like the queen of Bright Moon should be,” Angella dismisses. Apparently getting trapped in a pocket dimension can break even the strongest magical connection. They could try to help her re-establish a connection with it, much like Glimmer once helped Scorpia bond with the Black Garnet, but Angella is facing the possibility of a new life that she had never considered an option for her before: one of domesticity.

Her daughter has found her footing as a queen and is engaged. Her husband is back and they are both eager to make up for lost time. The war is over and the kingdom is at peace. Angella makes the same decision that Micah did after the war without even having to consult him: to retire. Like Micah, she will help here and there, and she will especially be a ceremonial presence at times and a part of Glimmer’s personal life again, but officially she has no desire to take the kingdom over again.

“I fought the Horde for decades. The Princess Alliance achieved in three years what I doubted was even possible. They should be the ones leading the way forward now,” Angella says when an official meeting is called to declare her new place in the monarchy. She is still on partial bedrest orders, needing to take things easy as she readjusts to life, but returning to Bright Moon has brought a light to her face that leaves her practically glowing.

Their mission, risky and uncertain as it was, has been a success. Angella is healthy despite the shock her body went through. Time didn’t pass in the pocket dimension. It didn’t feel like two years of nothing to her. It felt infinite and finite at once. From what Catra experienced, that seems right. It turns out that she was only gone for a few seconds when she leapt inside, but what passed inside definitely felt longer. In fact, it might have been *impossible* for it all to happen so quickly. Clearly time was variable.

Of course, Angella’s rescue wasn’t their only goal, even if it was their primary one, and it can’t be the only thing by which they measure their success. After four days, Mara hasn’t woken up on her own and several doctors, healers, and magical experts have been to see her. All any of them can say is that her body is in perfect condition, she doesn’t appear to have aged, and that regardless of these facts, she is in a coma. The magical experts estimate that – if she ever wakes – it will take years, maybe even more time than she has now her body is out of stasis.

Adora waits just until they get the second opinions before she becomes determined to try healing Mara herself. No one suggests otherwise. In fact, the only delay is transferring Mara to Bright Moon beforehand so she can have a full team of doctors on standby. They will be needed whether she wakes or not. Besides, Bright Moon is much closer to Mystacor too if they need further magical help. Adora waits until everything is ready with a manic anticipation. They have been successful so far, but it seems like Adora will consider the whole thing – and herself – a failure if they can’t wake Mara.

“Glimmer has both her parents back thanks to you,” Catra points out, her voice soft as she pets over Adora’s hair, trying to soothe her into sleep. They have decided to give Mara a night to adjust to her new bed in Bright Moon before healing her in the morning. Adora,

however, doesn't seem to be able to sleep. She even has Melog laying on and nuzzling her, but her eyes remain open, staring up at the ceiling.

"Thanks to *all* of us. It just feels… It feels like-" Adora cuts off, closing her eyes and taking a deep breath. After a moment she gently pats Melog's head and they reluctantly stand, moving to lay down beside her. Free of the weight, Adora rolls over and wraps her arms around Catra, squeezing her tightly. Catra immediately hugs her back, dropping a kiss into her hair and waiting for Adora to fight her way to full words.

"It feels like killing her. To pull her from stasis and let her waste away in a bed instead. At least she was somewhat aware in there," Adora whispers. Catra's heart plummets.

"Adora, being locked in a void dimension forever is *torture*. You've seen how grateful Angella is. Mara decided to come with you. She wanted to leave," Catra returns. Adora and Angella have both recounted what happened in the pocket dimension. Only She-ra seems to have been able to speak once inside, but as soon as she looked in, she saw Angella and called to her. Mara was so far away – and especially far above them – that Adora didn't see her at first.

When Adora leapt in she went straight for Angella. She instructed her to hold onto the line and, when she did so, Angella managed to point up, finally drawing Adora's attention to Mara. Adora used the light platforms that Catra saw to launch herself up to Mara's position, but she eventually realized that she would have to cut the safety line if she wanted to reach her, and especially if she wanted Angella reeled in before the countdown finished. That was when Catra panicked and jumped in herself.

When Adora reached Mara, Mara seemed awestruck and uncertain according to Adora, but she did reach for her and let herself be thrown over her shoulder. She wanted to leave. Adora is silent for a few moments as she considers that, tucking her face in against Catra's shoulder. Or maybe she is trying to smother herself in Catra's fluff as penance.

"From everything that you've told me, she had the same martyr aspirations you did. She didn't expect to live, Adora. Any extra time that you can give her will be a gift, but you haven't taken anything from her," Catra adds. Adora actually snorts a little at *martyr aspirations*, but after a few seconds she nods against Catra's shoulder and sighs.

"I just… want to help her. She helped me so much, even when we thought she was dead. I never could have accomplished any of this without her," Adora says. She still sounds guilty, though at least she isn't calling herself a murderer anymore. It is Adora's nature to feel guilty and it is always Catra's job to remind her that one person can't flawlessly solve all the world's problems.

"You've already helped her by freeing her. I'm sure she would be grateful even if she doesn't wake up for ten years – or never does," Catra tells her, raising one hand to begin petting Adora's hair again. Adora always finds the motion soothing. Catra is hopeful that She-ra will be able to wake her – or at least speed up the process – but nothing is known about the dimension she was in or her state before she was locked inside.

It took Angella an hour to wake up after two years inside – Mara was in there for at least a thousand years. If she is still asleep in a month and a half, then they should start worrying about her never waking, but logically it should take her longer to wake. Adora seems reluctant, but she nods against Catra. A moment later, she shifts, turning her head and getting settled draped across her. She seems to be settling in for sleep. Melog shifts too, bellycrawling close and draping themselves against both their sides.

Catra keeps petting Adora's hair as she settles down, letting her own eyes slowly close. Eventually Adora's breathing slows above her and only then does Catra let herself drift off.

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There is a trepidation in the room when Adora stands before Mara's bed. She has healed a few people during and after the war – they have discovered some of the limits to her healing as well, specifically that it can't fix old injuries or scarring – so she is fairly well-versed at it, but this is the first time it has ever felt like there is a *risk* to it. No one really thinks that exposing Mara's body healing magic will make her coma any worse but, well, it is on the list of possibilities.

This time, at least, Catra can be right at her side. She squeezes Adora's shoulder as she takes a deep breath, only dropping her hand when Adora reaches out to summon the sword. They are standing at Mara's bedside with doctors waiting on the other side and several members of the Princess Alliance – including Angella, leaning on Micah – waiting near the door of the room.

She-ra summoned, Adora looks down at Mara with trepidation for several seconds. Mara, as she has for days, just lies there, her chest rising and falling steadily. Adora raises the sword, positioning the tip facing Mara and closes her eyes. A few deep breaths and the telltale golden glow begins to wrap around her body. She-ra never looks more goddess-like than when she is healing, shining like a golden beacon as her hair and skirt whip around in an invisible breeze. Catra always finds herself a bit awed when she watches this.

She can't help a slight flinch back when the beam of gold shoots from She-ra's sword – it's *bright* and right next to her – but Mara's chest seems to raise toward the sword when the light hits her. Everyone watches with bated breath as Adora pours magic into her, eventually releasing the glowing aura with a heavy breath. She leans toward Catra, dropping She-ra in an instant. Catra hurries to put her arm around Adora, more concerned with supporting her than anything else at the moment. Healing always takes it out of her, but she isn't usually this winded. Then again, she isn't usually this worried about the result either.

Catra is focusing on Adora, but when Adora's eyes go wide upon looking down at Mara, Catra turns her head to look down at the bed too. Her breath hitches. Mara's eyes are narrow slivers, her lashes barely lifted, but she has enough cognition to be looking directly into Adora's eyes. Her lips are slightly parted but the rest of her is limp in the sheets. Adora's breathing is uneven as she reaches down and takes Mara's hand in her own, squeezing it.

“You’re safe. The world is safe,” Adora tries to assure her. Mara blinks slowly at her for a long moment while the two doctors at her bedside rush to check her vitals.

“Thank you,” Mara whispers, and then her eyes slip closed again.

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For several hours, Mara slips in and out of consciousness similar to how Angella did for the first hour. It is progress though, and most of all, a sign of hope. Catra waits with Adora as she paces back and forth, sometimes in Mara’s room and sometimes just outside of it, desperate to hear any news the moment it happens. Eventually one of the doctors opens the door and ushers them inside. Catra follows on Adora’s eager heels, Melog trailing right behind her.

Mara is inside, still lying on the bed, but her eyes are open and she has been partially sat up with pillows. She looks a little overwhelmed, but she lifts her head a little to watch them come in and her eyes light up upon spotting Adora. Adora’s hand twitches in an aborted motion when she reaches Mara’s bedside, but she doesn’t grab Mara’s hand, instead shifting to grab Catra’s and squeezing it tightly. Melog sits at her other side, leaning against her leg and offering support.

“How are you feeling?” Adora asks, her voice hopeful and anxious. Interestingly, Mara is looking back at Adora just as eagerly. She is clearly tired, but her eyes roam over Adora to take her in just like how Adora does to her. From what Adora has told Catra, Mara knew a bit about Adora through Madame Razz. Their knowledge of each other wasn’t a one-way street despite Adora not having been born yet. It must be surreal for both of them to finally be in the same room.

“Like I floated in the sea for years before washing ashore. Forces are suddenly acting on my body and its exhausting to lie here. But I’m alive,” she returns. Her voice is soft, kind in a similar way to Micah’s. She has some fine lines settled in her skin that Catra isn’t sure if she didn’t notice at first or are new, but they just make her look mature, like she has a wisdom to her. She is older than Adora by several years, maybe a more fitting age to take on the role of planet savior, though Catra doesn’t think anyone is ever ready for it. It feels odd to compare the two, though.

“They won’t tell me how long it’s been. They just say it’s safe and that I need to adjust first,” Mara says. It isn’t quite a complaint, but she and Adora exchange a look that is almost commiserating. Adora chuckles and shakes her head.

“It’s not their fault, they don’t know about Madame Razz. We think it’s been about a thousand years. It’s hard to pin down once that much time has passed,” Adora tells her. Mara’s gaze softens, her focus waning from Adora’s face as she nods almost absently. With Angella, the blow was soft and easy to deliver quickly. A thousand years should be a shocking revelation, but Mara just accepts it as if she anticipated it. Then again, Madame

Razz might have said the number to her once. Madame Razz isn't really the numbers type, though. Even when she bakes she seems to pull ingredient amounts out of thin air.

"Madame Razz is still around. I think she's probably exactly the same. I can go get her if you'd like to see someone familiar. It might take me awhile to find her, though," Adora offers, a little of her eagerness becoming apparent again. She has that air about her that just screams *I want to help*. Mara blinks, her eyes coming back into focus, and then she smiles, her entire face softening. Catra is suddenly struck with how similar her and Adora's expressions are. Of course they look very different, but they have the same earnest warmth to them both.

"I would love that. She was the sweetest," Mara agrees. The past tense implies that Mara is having at least a little trouble with the idea of adjusting to life a thousand years later, but it would be shocking if she weren't. At this point, people don't even remember when her civilization was called. Mara's eyes wander and Catra blinks with surprise as she finds herself at the center of Mara's focus. Mara's eyes sweep over her before she glances back to Adora.

"Going to introduce me to your magicat friend?" Mara asks, a warm, teasing quality to her voice. Adora instantly lights up a little, like she always does when she gets to talk about Catra. She drops Catra's hand to instead wrap her arm around her, grinning as she looks down at her.

"This is Catra, my fiancé. Her love kind of helped me save the world," Adora brags proudly. It is something she likes to say often, but Catra still blushes and ducks her head a little. She elbows Adora, but it isn't hard. It is for show more than anything else. Adora doesn't let go of her, keeping her arm around her as she looks back to Mara, her expression softening a little. "I couldn't have done it without you, either," she adds. Mara's breath hitches. She reacts to that just how Catra expects Adora would – tears gather in the corner of her eyes.

"The Galactic Horde is gone? Eternia isn't going to use the Heart?" Mara asks, an edge of desperation to her voice despite how she says the words like she is merely confirming what she already knows. She needs Adora to say the words to her before she can rest easy. Catra isn't used to some of the words she uses, but Adora has done some translating of First Ones' writing since the end of the war and she can at least approximate what that means given when they have found. Adora nods quickly, reaching down and finally taking Mara's hand with her free one now.

"I used the failsafe to safely release the magic stored in the Heart. It healed Etheria and let me defeat Horde Prime. Many of his clones have been reintegrated into society. The entire universe is healing," Adora assures her. The tension that was suddenly introduced to Mara's body seeps away as she relaxes again, her gaze a bit distant like she can't believe it. Then again, she gave her life to merely delay what seemed inevitable back then. Stopping it completely – especially healing and moving on from it – must be a lot to take in.

"Eternia?" Mara asks after several long moment of lying in the bed with an expression of disbelief. Adora hesitates. The word appears in First Ones' documents sometimes. It is carved on a First Ones ruin in the Whispering Woods too. They don't know for sure what it

is, aside from a place, but they have their guesses based on the fact that it was clearly important to the First Ones.

“A thousand years loses a lot. Was that… our homeworld?” Adora asks, looking at Mara with a tinge of desperation to her gaze. There is so much that Adora doesn’t know about herself. She is the only surviving First One anyone knows about. Most planets they have made contact with have forgotten – or never known – the First Ones’ civilization. Sometimes they are called different names, like the Precursors or Eternals or Grey Sorcerers, but no one has heard anything of them in hundreds of years.

They haven’t explored far in Darla though, often needed on Etheria, so it is possible that they will still find some remnant pocket of survivors that could have been Adora’s origin. They don’t have much evidence for that aside from Horde Prime’s speculation though, so all they really have is blind hope and whatever they manage to translate from what they find left behind.

Mara’s expression tinges with sadness, but she gives Adora a small nod. Adora tries to offer her an assuring smile back, but it just comes out small and tremulous. Catra tightens her arm around Adora’s back, trying to give her a bit of support. Adora has come to terms with the fact that she is an alien, but it is hard when you are the last of your kind like she and Melog seem to be. Melog turns their head at the thought, nuzzling against Adora’s hip in assurance.

“We haven’t been able to find charts that show its location to check on it, but… Horde Prime seemed convinced that he had wiped out all the First- *Eternians* long ago,” Adora tells Mara, her expression pained and anxious. She clearly expects that to be devastating news to Mara, but Mara’s expression is just one of morose acceptance. She nods, her gaze wandering and growing unfocused again.

“We sealed our own fate. We were starting to stoop to his level to fight him. Maybe it’s for the best if Etheria was safe in the end,” Mara says, her voice still distant. Catra squeezes her arm around Adora’s waist to draw her attention and sends her a meaningful look when their eyes make contact. Mara definitely needs a bit of room to process. She is going to have to relearn the world she lives in, too. It must be exhausting to even think about. Adora gives Catra a slight nod before looking back to Mara.

“We’ll give you some time to rest. You can call for me at any time. There will always be someone nearby who can run to get me. Catra and I live here, so I’ll be here even in the middle of the night,” Adora promises Mara. Mara’s gaze flicks to her, but her eyes are already hooded with exhaustion. She gives a slight nod, clearly not up to more. Adora and Catra both murmur quiet goodbyes before they walk from the room with Melog on their heels.

“I told you she would be grateful for anything you did,” Catra points out when they are down the hall, nudging Adora a little as they walk. She just wants to lift the somber mood that fell on Adora with the mention of Eternia. A small smile lifts at the downturned expression on Adora’s face. She sends Catra a look that is clearly supposed to be exasperated but just comes out fond.

“You were right, as always, and I was wrong. Happy?” Adora asks. Catra grins, happily leaning into Adora’s side. Adora obediently lifts an arm and wraps it around her.

“You’re ready to be married,” Catra decides. Adora laughs lightly in response, shooting Catra a fond look. They’re technically engaged just like Glimmer and Bow, but they are only in the beginning stages of planning their wedding. Namely, they are trying to figure out how small they can get away with making it. They are aware that most of Etheria would want to come She-ra’s wedding, but the day isn’t about Etheria *or* She-ra – it’s about Adora and Catra. Besides, if Catra had to say her vows in front of anyone outside of their immediate friend group she might jump out a window.

They aren’t in a rush. Bright Moon’s concept of marriage and partnership is relatively new to them anyway. They just know that they will be together forever and don’t see the point of waiting more than the year they already have at this point. Besides, the idea of a wedding does sound romantic. It will happen whenever they have sorted the details out and are ready for it, but for the moment, Adora already has pleasing her future wife down.

Catra is just relieved to see Adora smiling, the weight of the last few weeks lifted off her shoulders. Waiting for the portal to be built was nerve-wracking, going through it was terrifying, and even once the “rescue” was complete, Mara’s recovery was still hanging over their heads. She may have complications yet, but she is awake, talking, and grateful to be here even knowing how much has disappeared since she last walked Etheria. It will be hard to readjust, but they just have to hope that Mara finds something that makes it worth it.

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Mara has the maturity of Angella and the innocent wonder of a child. She is in love with life. Catra watches from the branches of a large willow tree in the Bright Moon castle gardens as Mara watches the bugs flitting about with fascination, sometimes following one around and talking to it, asking it rhetorical questions about what it is doing and complimenting the glimmer of the scales. She reminds Catra a *lot* of Adora. She wonders if it is a She-ra thing to just be… wholesome and loving.

She expected Mara to be a lot more depressed, mourning the world she once tried to protect. It survived, but what is left a thousand years later might as well be another planet. Instead, she seems entranced by it. She happily badgers people with questions – though with a bit more social awareness than Adora usually has – and soaks in information like a sponge. She has a room, but Catra isn’t sure she has ever been in it considering that she never seems to leave the library, pouring over fiction and non-fiction alike with equal voracity.

“I didn’t know if the world would survive. I didn’t know if it would just end up a ruined husk. Getting to see it not only live, but *flourish*…. It’s the best gift that I could have asked for,” Mara gushes when she spots Catra lounging in the branches with Melog, watching with amusement. Catra’s tail twitches. She can’t fault Mara for that. She is honestly relieved that Mara has managed to find the joy in her situation.

She knows that Mara and Adora have had some emotional conversations in private about the burden of She-ra, the sacrifices they have both made or *expected* to have to make, and about Eternia. Mara is experiencing what Adora did after the war: being free of expectation and sacrifice for the very first time. She has done her duty and sacrificed *everything* for the world. Now she gets to just live in it. She always tried to enjoy it along the way before, apparently, but her role as She-ra had to come first.

Adora knows that well. She has some experience with it, but they both have things to teach each other about living.

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It takes nearly a week for Mara to be cleared to leave the castle. Right away, Adora and Catra accompany her into the Whispering Woods. Mara marvels at it like she does everything else, eagerly rushing towards plants and animals and asking what they are called, if they were around before the Heart released, and if she can touch them. Despite her excitement, she does reserve some of her energy. She is going to need it if she will make it to Madame Razz's hut.

Madame Razz doesn't usually leave the woods. She isn't always easy to find, either. Her hut definitely moves, which is a rarity amongst the settlements and buildings in the trees. Usually everything else moves around them, but they have used Entrapta's predictive maps and the hut itself moves around. Razz seems unphased by it herself. She never has trouble finding her way back when she wanders off or leads one of them on a berry-picking expedition.

They aren't sure if they will be able to find the hut today – sometimes they just don't – but the woods lead them in until the foliage turns familiar again. If there was ever a time that a visit was important, it is now. When they reach the clearing around the hut, Catra and Adora are walking hand-in-hand with Mara just behind them. She seems anxious. She hasn't seen Madame Razz in a long time, after all. She had Adora describe the woman to her when they first started planning this and she seemed in disbelief that the timewalker was just as she remembered.

Everything she said to both of them implied that she had lived and would keep living for a very long time, but with everything else gone, it is hard to believe that one thing – one *person* – clung on. Still, when they reach the clearing, Madame Razz is standing outside her hut, waving her broom at the roof and trying to scold Lookee into coming down. She talks to him a lot, though Catra has yet to see any evidence that he is real. She doesn't know if he is another figment of time that she has lost track of, a result of a slightly eschew imagination, or maybe just invisible. Given that it's Razz, any of them seem possible.

"Now what are you hiding for! It's just me around. When did I become intimidating?" Madame Razz questions indignantly, putting her fists on her hips. She looks like she's sulking. Catra can't help but snicker a little as they approach.

“He must have heard us coming,” she calls out to the old woman. Madame Razz startles, dropping her broom with surprise as she turns around. She squints at them, reaching up to adjust her glasses. It is always up in the air if she will know Catra or if she will be surprised by how young they look. She always knows Adora, even if she still calls her Mara often. Today, Razz smiles at them, lighting up as she turns back around to gather up her broom.

“Oh, dearies! It’s been ages since you visited! You missed our tea party. I had to spend all afternoon making sure Swift Wind didn’t eat all of Lookee’s cakes,” Madame Razz declares as she turns back around with the broom now leaned against her shoulder. They never planned any tea party, but Catra doesn’t correct her. Adora offers her an apologetic smile.

“We’re sorry, we were very busy. We brought someone with us to make up for it, though,” Adora tells her, letting go of Catra’s hand so they can both step aside and give Madame Razz a clear view of Mara behind them. She could have been easily seen over their shoulders – after all, she is taller than both of them – but Razz’s eyesight is far from good. Madame Razz blinks, genuine shock entering her face for the first time that Catra has ever seen. After a moment, Razz reaches up and adjusts her glasses again like they must be wrong.

“Hi, Razz. It’s been a long time,” Mara greets, her voice warm but a bit shy. She waves a little, her hand still low by her hip. She is clearly very nervous about Razz’s reaction. Razz, for her part, gapes.

“This hasn’t happened before. It’s been so long since something happened for the first time,” she says, quietly, as if to herself. Some of Mara’s anxiety is replaced with a kind expression tinged by softness. She steps forward and kneels, placing a hand on Razz’s shoulder and smiling to her.

“The world is new to me too now. We can experience it together,” Mara offers. Her voice is *always* kind, but there is a hopefulness to it now too. Catra has yet to meet Razz and have her be surprised by her presence. The first time she met Catra, she asked her why she cut her hair again. It took a minute for Catra to work out that Razz was used to her having long hair in the future. She only realized it so quickly because Adora had explained her whole-time travel deal before they finally met. Razz’s world is so strange, it must be surreal for her to experience something for the first time instead of the hundredth.

Madame Razz smiles at Mara, the motion soft and a bit unsure, but equally hopeful. She reaches up with both hands, framing Mara’s face and turning it a little in her hands as if to check it is really there. For once, she is gentle and careful, almost like she is afraid Mara will vanish into smoke if she presses too hard. Madame Razz draws in a sad, rattling breath.

“I’ve missed you, dearie. I would love that. I have so much I never got to show you,” Razz says, her voice soft and a bit sad. Catra feels a pang in her chest at the words. Razz, it seems, thought she had lost Mara. She hasn’t experienced any moments in the future with her after her return – at least not that she knows of and was able to distinguish from their time in the past. Mara has tears in her eyes already, shifting to wrap her arms around Razz and squeeze her in a tight hug.

“I’m so glad that you’re here. You showed me the magic of this world. You helped me so much,” Mara tells her. Catra sees a few tears escape down her cheeks. At Catra’s side, Adora

steps closer, taking Catra's hand in her own and squeezing it tightly. One glance at her face reveals that she is growing emotional too, but she manages not to cry outright. Madame Razz throws her arms up and hugs Mara back just as tightly.

"Oh, dearie, the magic was in you. I just helped you see it," Razz assures her. Mara gives a soft huff, halfway between a laugh and a sob, and pulls back. She reaches up to wipe her tears, but Razz beats her to it, sweeping them away with her knobbly fingers. "Come on, Mara. Let's go inside. This occasion calls for a pie. You can tell me all about what you've been up to," Madame Razz offers, taking Mara's hand once she is done with her face and gesturing to the entrance of her hut. Mara sniffles one last time, but she offers Razz a smile so genuine that it makes Catra's heart hurt to look at it.

"I'd like that," Mara returns, her voice soft. She lets Razz lead her to the hut. When Razz sweeps aside the entry cloth with her broom, she pauses and looks back over her shoulder.

"Well hurry along now! I need baking helpers!" she calls to them, beckoning them impatiently inside. Adora laughs softly and Catra chuckles herself as they walk forward, following her and Mara inside. They will gladly be relegated to mere assistants today. Razz and Mara have a lot to catch up on, but they have each other, and that's something neither of them thought that they would ever have again. Catra is happy to facilitate some of their time together. Besides, there are worse ways to spend an afternoon than in Razz's hut. Catra even smiles as Razz gently leads Mara to a seat and then turns to thrust a mixing bowl in her hands.

She sends Adora look over Razz's head and they both exchange a smile as Razz begins to gush about how she has never seen Adora and Mara together at *once*. The impossibility of the situation means nothing to Razz – it is merely exciting. She babbles as Adora and Catra start preparing the mixing bowls. Mara listens with shining eyes. No one has ever looked so happy to listen to Razz talk. It is all worth it for that, not to mention the joy on Adora's face as she watches too.

The portal incident has long been a dark cloud hanging over Catra, but if it is what lead them to realizing this was possible and these two reuniting, maybe she can find the silver lining in it, especially with Angella rescued to. Even in the darkest moments of her life, there was an inevitable light to be found, she just couldn't see it at the time. She sees it now. It beams like a light when Mara smiles.

Chapter End Notes

I have a meta post on my tumblr about how I don't think that Crew-ra actually intended for Mara to be implied to be alive, but all the rules of the portal reality leave it open as a possibility, so I included it in this fic and tried to find a way to turn it positive (I do find her having missed thousands of years and the collapse of her own culture… dark, but I tried to think what would be an in-character reason for her to find happiness now). You probably won't find mention of Mara being saved again in one of my fics (unless I

decide to do a Certain miniseries <.<), but Angella being saved is canon as far as I am concerned and has already been referenced in Y&I&M.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!